

ENCHANTED EVENING



RESTAURANT FOR AMBIENCE **MAGIQUE, DELHI**

Olive may have reopened at The Diplomat at Chanakyapuri, but restaurateur A.D. Singh will have to work doubly hard at winning back socialite Delhi's most-favoured-restaurant status. Because while he's been away, food impresario Marut Sikka has come in with a winning proposition called Magique, and rapidly captured the hearts and stomachs of discerning diners. The second first. Sikka's speciality may be Indian

HEMANT CHAWLA



food, but Magique offers its clientele a fusion of Asian foods. Think Norwegian salmon with miso and garlic potato mash, sushi with mango and chicken, and wontons stuffed with crab and litchi. The look and location, in the verdant Garden of Five Senses, also play stellar roles. The 90-cover inside and out restaurant, designed by architect Ambrish Arora, is enchanting. Entering the garden, particularly at night, is like taking a quick trip out of the city. You drive up in isolation from the gate to be welcomed by valet parkers and other staff who escort you through the greenery that lines the meandering path into a candlelit courtyard which leads onto a patio and dining room. In summer, Sikka lets the mist fans, hidden among the shrubs lining the roof, do their little number. But it is in winter that Magique really scores. It is the perfect place to loll over a Sunday brunch, or down cocktails (Sikka's boys do a mean martini) and good conversation. One word of advice though. Do leave the children at home. Romantic ambience and kids don't mix. **by Shampa Dhar-Kamath**

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